Babur consulted with his best minds at the Langar of Mīr Ghiyāṣ about the route for return to Kābul. They all reached an agreement and said, ‘It is winter, the mountain-road is difficult and dangerous; the Qandahār road, though a little longer, is safe and easy.’ But Qāsim Beg opposed the proposition. He said, ‘That road is long; you will go by this one.’ Finally, they decided to take the mountain road.

A Pashāī named Pīr Sulṭān was Babur’s guide during this time.

Brief About Pashāī

The pashai are a Dardic ethnolinguistic group who primarily reside in eastern Afghanistan. They are the descendants of a Rig Vaidik Gāndhārī tribe and currently, their population is estimated to be around half a million. They are considered to be the oldest ethnic minority in Afghanistan.

As of now, they are currently concentrated in the northern parts of Laghman and Nangarhar. Few also lie in the parts of Kunar, Kapisa, Parwan, Nuristan, and Panjshir. Most of the Pashai consider themselves Pashtuns speaking a special language, and few are bilingual in Pashto. They are also found in the Chitral district of north-western Pakistan.

The documentation of many experts shows that the Pashai people practised Hindu and Buddhist faiths.[*] They stayed in Kunar and Laghman valleys near Jalalabad in north-eastern Afghanistan until they were displaced to a less fertile mountainous region by successive waves of immigration by Ghilji Pashtuns.[†] Interestingly, Marco Polo came across this part of the world in the thirteenth century and he writes, ‘You must know that ten days’ journey to the south of Badashan there is a Province called PASHAI, the people of which have a peculiar language, and are Idolaters, of a brown complexion. They are great adepts in sorceries and the diabolic arts. The men wear earrings and brooches of gold and silver set with stones and pearls. They are a pestilent people and a crafty; and they live upon flesh and rice. Their country is very hot.’[*]

Currently, the majority of Pashai follow Sunni Islam and get referred to as Kohistani.[†] Abu’l-Fath Jalal-ud-din Muhammad Akbar, (the Tīmūrid King popularly known as Akbar) had sent his younger brother Mirza Muhammad Hakim, to wage a war against the Kafirs (infidels) of Katwar in AD 1582.[‡] He was a staunch adherent of the missionary-minded Naqshbandi Sufi order and a semi-independent governor of Kābul. The *Sifat-nama* gives Muhammad Hakim the epithet of Darvis Khan Gazi. This clearly speaks aloud of his spirit to war